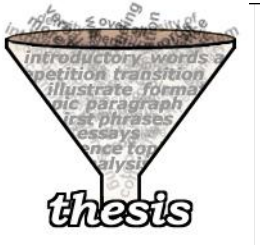
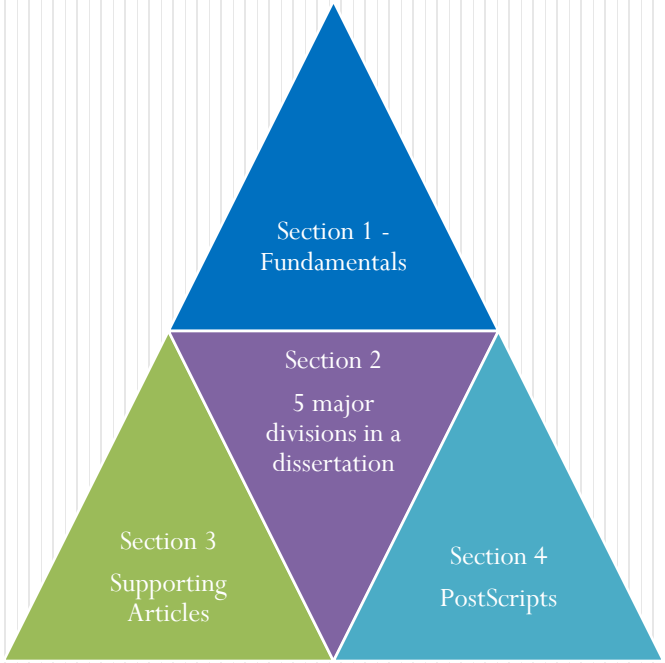
Foundation 4

Thesis Statements



Session 1.6



The precise statement of any problem is the most important step in its solution.

Edwin Bliss

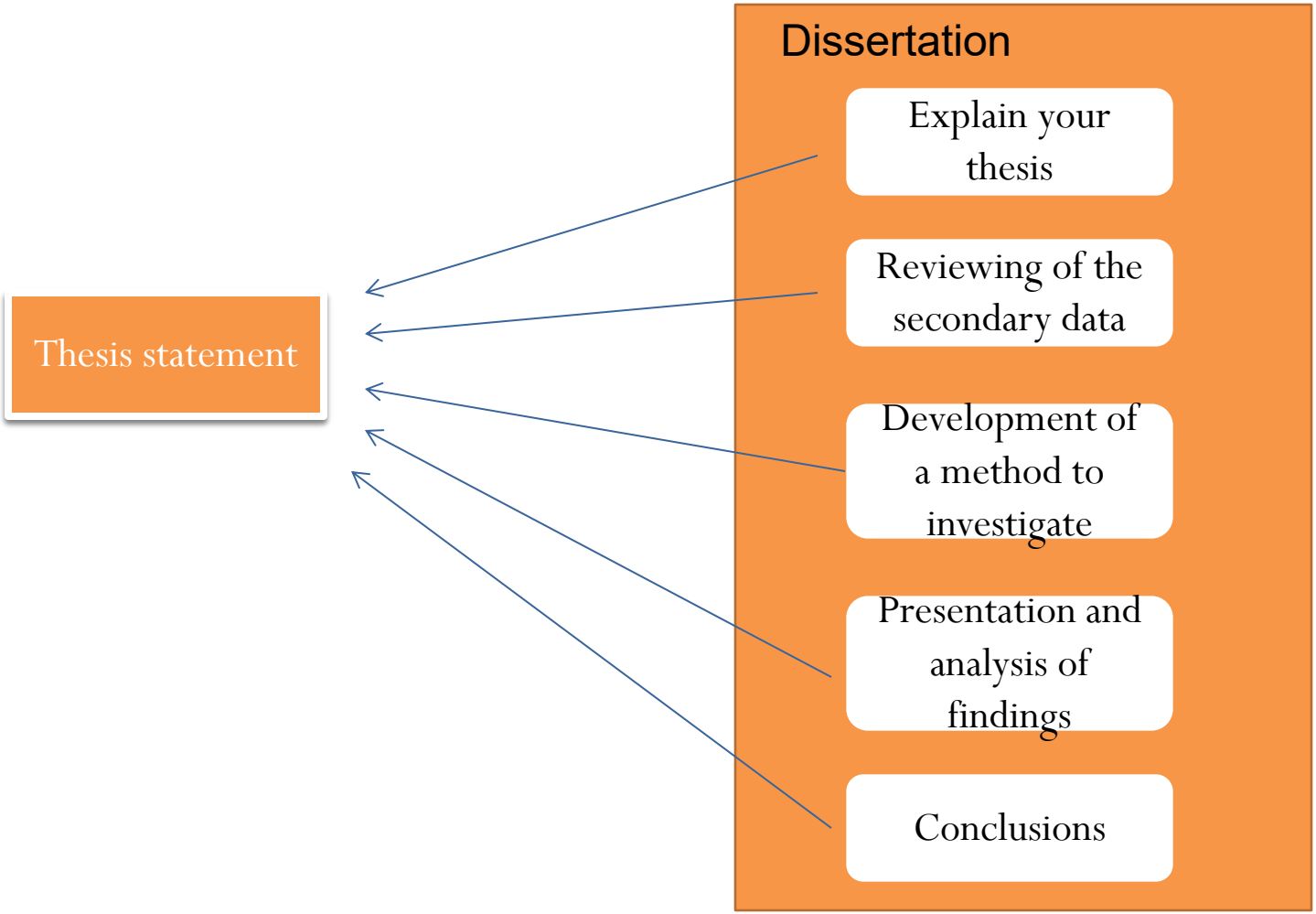
Foundation 4: Thesis Statement

- Having a good thesis statement is central to the way that you construct your dissertation.
- What is a thesis statement?
- The thesis is the central argument of your work. A thesis statement names that argument.
- Once you have identified a problem, you develop a thesis about it.
- You take a stand about the problem or hypothesize a solution to the problem.
- A thesis is an assertion that you put forward as being (supposedly) true.

Foundation 4: Thesis Statement

A thesis is a guess, an unproven assertion that you will investigate in your dissertation. A thesis can be argued with evidence, or it can be empirically tested, it generally referred to as a 'research hypothesis'. In either case you are forced to take a clear position regarding the problem that you have identified, and to either argue for that position, considering the evidence for and against, or to develop a way of testing.

The role of a thesis in an academic work



- A *thesis statement* allows the researchers to precisely define what they will investigate.
- It prevents your dissertation from meandering all over the place.
- A thesis statement gives you clear boundaries and a clear reason to do what you do.
- Whenever you do anything in your dissertation, the reasons should always be 'because it is necessary in order to assess my thesis statement.

The purpose of academic work is to come up with new knowledge. A good thesis statement should lead you up to that. This does *not* mean that it needs to be an original thesis in order to lead to new knowledge.

Devising a thesis statement

- Where to look for ideas to turn into a thesis statement:
  - Yourself: think about problems that you have encountered in your work environment or that you have encountered in your previous academic work. Chat with supervisors about your ideas.
  - Go to the library: Use keywords to do searches on. Read through articles available on the topic. Read dissertation outlines on the subject.
  - Look at the further research section in dissertations / articles.
  - Investigate ALL possible concerns before you commit, because everything that you do later in your dissertation is influenced by your choice of these statements.

Try conceptualizing your thesis statement as a marriage. Once you've committed you must be true to it; changing it is, like a divorce, unpleasant, messy, difficult and often expensive.

If you have a good thesis statement, it will be your North Star: If you follow it faithfully, it will guide you home safely.

- A thesis statement don't name a topic or a problem that you've identified. It must take a stand about something. It must give you something to argue, to test, to prove, to probe.
  - Is the following a thesis statement? A model describing the consumer behavior of adolescent boys in Switzerland for marketing purposes.
  - Prove? Disaprove? Argue? Disagree? Agree?
  - BUT: One can argue for or against: The consumer behavior of adolescent boys in Switzerland can be effectively described in a five-phase model for marketing purposes.
- A person knowledgeable in the field must be able to challenge or argue your thesis.
- It is not a question.

Do public servants resign their posts because they earn too little in public service?	**?**
Low earnings is the primary reason for public servants to resign their posts.	?
Low earnings is NOT the primary reason for public servants to resign their posts.	?

Criteria for good thesis statements

Is the thesis statement you are considering:
A single thesis statement that a reasonable person in your field could agree or disagree with
An unambiguous assertion -
Worthwhile?
Limited in Scope
Feasible in terms of Primary Resources?
Based on existing theory?
Testable by you?
Doable in a reasonable time?
Within your area of interest/in synergy with career goals?

Don’t worry if you are going to prove your thesis statement right or wrong.

You are not judged whether you proved your thesis statement right or wrong. You are judged on whether you investigated a worthwhile issue in a reliable manner and came to a well-substantiated conclusion about it.

- Avoid doing research that will happen in the future.
- When you are happy with what you have – talk to your supervisor!
- Negotiate the thesis statement – don't work on it if it is not approved by your supervisor.

Criteria for good thesis statements

- A good thesis statement is one that will allow you to complete a passing dissertation as quickly and painlessly as possible.
- The following are things to consider when you write your thesis statement ..

Is the thesis statement you are considering:
A single thesis statement that a reasonable person in your field could agree or disagree with?
Comment: Be careful that you do not focus on more than one topic within one thesis. If so, complete two degrees ☺ -A trap that students fall into because they are 'scared' they have not done enough. - Remember that you will need two methods, two body sections, two conclusions etc.

Criteria for good thesis statements

Is the thesis statement you are considering:
An unambiguous assertion -
Comment: Thesis statement sets up your readers' expectations about your work. Readers must understand *exactly* what you mean to investigate or argue – nothing more, nothing less, and nothing different. Good thesis statements are very, very clear. You will not be able to put all the implications into one sentence. You will have paragraphs describing these under your statement. Most of your first chapter is explaining what your thesis statement means. For example, problem statements, research objectives, definitions of terms, research questions etc. are all used to support the thesis statement.
Exercise: To find out how unambiguous your thesis statement is, write it down on 10 cards and give it to friends and family and ask them what does it mean. If they don't all agree, you have a problem.

Is the thesis statement you are considering:
Worthwhile?
Classic test: read it and then imagine someone saying "So what?" Your answer is the significance of the work that your thesis statement leads to. Note that significant is not a synonym for difficult.
You only need to make a contribution to the existing knowledge. It does not need to be hugely significant in order for you to get your degree. Academic work is *incremental*.

Is the thesis statement you are considering:	
Limited in Scope?	
Reduce the scope while retaining the significance.	
Thesis statements that deal with focused problems lead to dissertations with reliable conclusions that actually get completed.	
Compare:	
South African businesses need a new management paradigm in order to remain competitive in the global economy.	South African paint manufacturers who have nurtured a strong black middle management component have raised the productivity of their factory employees above that of their competitors.

Is the thesis statement you are considering:

Limited in Scope?

When you are busy to fine-tune your thesis statement with delimitations, try to avoid what has already been done, and focus on the original in your research.

Explicit delineation protects you from criticism such as 'why didn't you do this or that'.

Only if the proper monitoring Infrastructure and procedures are Implemented as describes in App A

Only for first time offenders

Electronic monitoring of offenders offers an effective solution to the overcrowding in South African prisons without compromising the safety of citizens.

Only government prisons

Etc., etc., etc.

Only white collar criminals And petty theft, no violent crimes

Only a particular type of device, Not other monitoring devices.

Is the thesis statement you are considering:
Feasible in terms of primary sources?
Can you get the primary data that supports your thesis statement?
The easier it is for you to collect the data you need, the sooner you will be able to complete your dissertation.
The better the quality of the data you use, the more reliable your conclusions will be.
For doctoral dissertations it is highly exceptional that you will be allowed to work exclusively with secondary sources.
Sometimes data may lead to the thesis statement ..You have the data and you then ask what value can I derive from this data?
If it seems as if it is difficult to get all the data you need, first consider alternative ways of answering the thesis statement. Or bend the thesis statement. If neither works, reconsider.

Is the thesis statement you are considering:
Based on existing theory?
There should be a theory based on the work that you are planning to do.

Is the thesis statement you are considering:
Testable by you?
If you can not test your thesis statement then there is no point in considering the dissertation on the topic.
If you can't construct a rational argument backed up by evidence, don't pose the thesis.
You need to give readers a good reason to believer, or at least consider carefully, whatever it is that you argue. The only way to do so is to have a good method.

Is the thesis statement you are considering:
Doable in a reasonable amount of time?
Check all the possible things that may slow you down: • Do you need funding? • Do you need data from somewhere else? • Is it feasible to monitor the group of people that you intend? • Is your supervisor committed to your thesis statement?
Don't take risk! Consider the pros and cons of commencing work for each of your statements.

Is the thesis statement you are considering:
Within your area of interest/in synergy with career goals?
Always good to compliment your area of interest/work with your research goals.
If you consider to do research related to your work interest, remember that you need to consider intellectual property.
Remember dissertations are the property of the University. The moment it is published ANYONE may use what ever was written within the work.
Consider a supervisor that is also interested in your topic – be careful to work in something that ONLY interest your supervisor. Be careful of 'larger' projects.

Exercise

- Complete the following thesis statements by adding the specific points, claims or areas of investigation that you think should feature in the essay.
  - The life expectancy of the average person is increasing because of …
  - The life expectancy of the average person is increasing because of improved nutrition, greater awareness of health issues and better medical treatment.

Exercise

- Complete the following thesis statements by adding the specific points, claims or areas of investigation that you think should feature in the essay.
  - Technology is changing our lives in three important areas: …
  - Technology is changing our life in three important areas: in the home, at work and in our leisure activities.

Exercise

- Complete the following thesis statements by adding the specific points, claims or areas of investigation that you think should feature in the essay.
  - A teacher must have the following qualities: …
    - A teacher must have the following qualities: patience, interpersonal skills, a love of children and an authoritative demeanour.
  - The purpose of this paper is to examine…
    - The purpose of this paper is to examine the changes that have taken place in language teaching over the past decade and to suggest some desirable changes for the future. (Any topic would fit here - but make sure that your statement is suitably narrow!)

- Owning an automobile is a necessity both…
  - Owning an automobile is a necessity both for career women and for mothers of small children.
- Poverty has numerous negative consequences for society, including…
  - Poverty has numerous negative consequences for society, including crime, drug abuse and prostitution.

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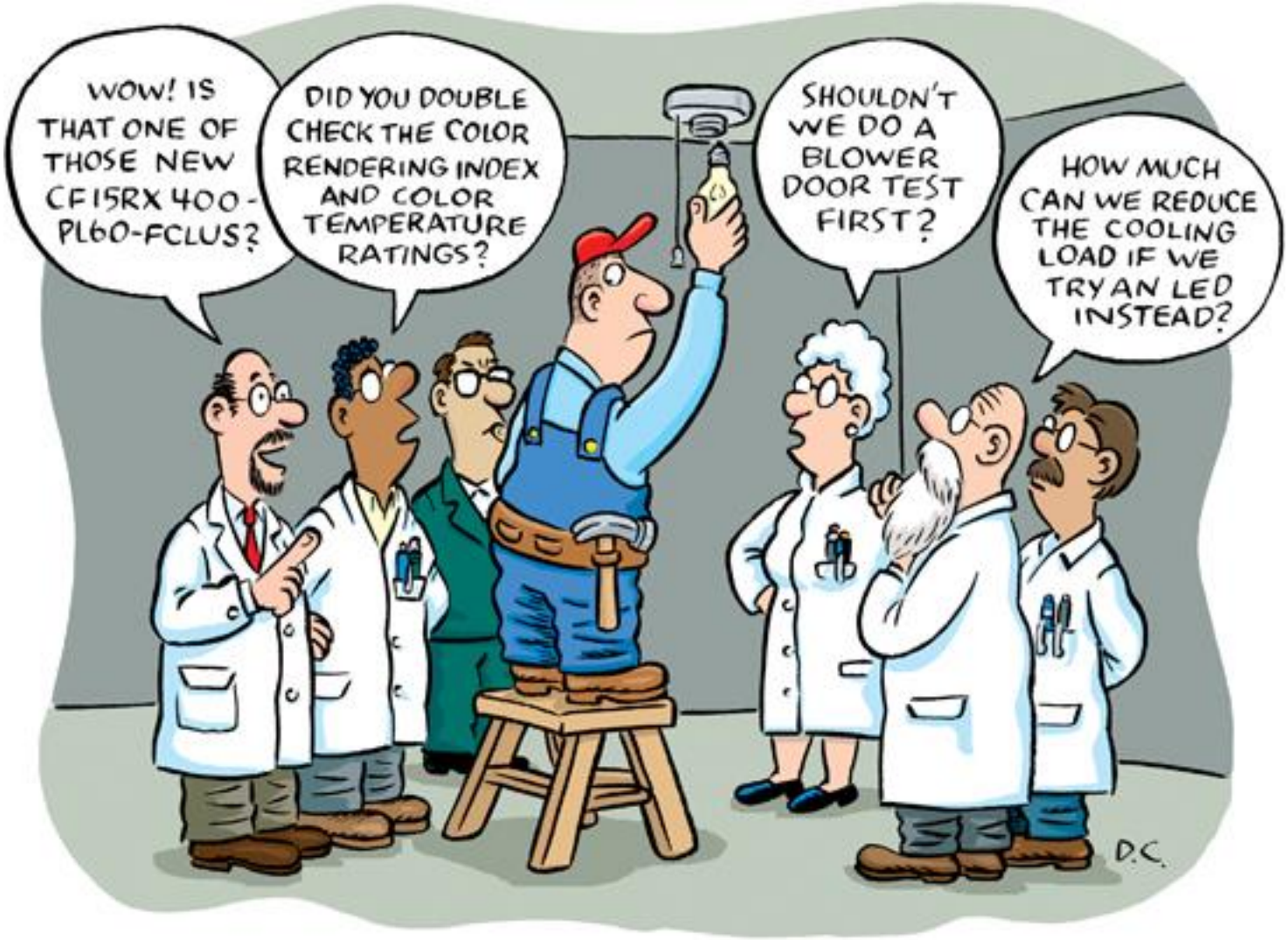
Type in your thesis statement

https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1YsI7-6-cV_mCNjMGbpIszmrdB6kO0d7V/edit?usp=sharing&ouid=117919985981529091514&rtpof=true&sd=true

A good thesis statement leads to a good dissertation.



To session 1.5